

Year 5 GP Timed Practice

Band Descriptors and Possible Points

- 1. The family no longer plays an influential role in raising teenagers.’ How true is this of your society?**

Terms & scope • ‘Family’: Refers to biological/familial relationships and the legal definition of family in Singapore society. This would include nuclear and extended family structures, as well as evolving family structures like blended families, single-parent families, etc. • ‘No longer’: This suggests that the family had played an influential role in raising teenagers in the past, and that there has been a significant shift over time, resulting in a diminished influence of the family in raising teenagers. This presupposes a comparison between the past and the present. • ‘Influential role’: This involves examining various aspects in the way the family can impact the upbringing and development of teenagers e.g. socialisation, emotional support, health (physical and mental), guidance and role modelling (e.g. decision making, life skills) and evaluating the intensity/depth of the impact the family has on the teenagers. • ‘Raising teenagers’: This should consider the developmental stage and needs of teenagers. Factors to consider include teenagers’ need for independence and autonomy, a developmental phase where they seek their own identity, the importance of peers to teenagers, their cognitive and emotional developmental needs, and the preparation to transit to adulthood. • ‘Your society’: Demonstrate a sensitivity to/awareness of the context of modern Singapore (e.g. cultural values, educational pressures, dual-income households, multiculturalism, technological advancements) that could affect significance of the family in raising teenagers.	
Band 4 & above	Band 3
• Engages with ‘influential role’ and ‘no longer’ as outlined in the terms and scope. • Identifies connections between issues and ideas, such as societal changes, cultural influences, modern technology on the family's role in raising teenagers.	• Largely lists strengths and weaknesses of a family and not consistently focused on its influence on teenagers. • Discusses concept of family without clear reference to SG. Band 2 • Hijacks the question by saying it is not the family but other stakeholders • Misinterpretation of ‘family’ to include socio-cultural networks and support networks (e.g. mentors, religious and/or community groups)

Why does the family still play an influential role in raising teenagers:

1. The **ingrained cultural expectation of the core function of the family being the significant agent of socialisation** has made the family retain its influence over the lives of teenagers in Singapore. This establishes the family as a primary source of guidance, moral teachings and values inculcation for teenagers. From an early age, teenagers are socialised to recognise the family as a central institution that imparts cultural values, ethics, and behaviours. This is reinforced through social norms, educational systems, and societal customs that prioritise familial cohesion and harmony, all of which results in a **societal framework that emphasises the importance of the role of the family** in shaping teenagers' lives despite external influences.
2. **Many teens in SG still rely on parents financially** and this affects the extent of influence parents/families have on their children e.g. on their choice of schools and subjects, sense of independence, self-esteem, and future financial planning. **Parents may also have more control over a teen's lifestyle and choices when they are financially dependent**, potentially leading to disagreements or a lack of autonomy. Conversely, financial support can also create a stronger bond between parent and child, offering a safety net and reducing stress related to immediate financial needs.

Why does the family no longer play an influential role in raising teenagers:

1. As a multicultural society influenced greatly by **globalisation and cultural exchanges**, Singapore has experienced transformative shifts in family structures, characterised by the rise of dual-income households and an augmented reliance on external institutions. Teenagers are **exposed to diverse cultural values, ideas, and perspectives**. This multifaceted exposure has the potential to recalibrate the balance of influence, whereby teenagers may now find themselves **seeking guidance and support from multiple diverse sources** beyond the confines of their immediate family.
2. The ubiquity of technology and the proliferation of media platforms have vastly broadened the information landscape accessible to teenagers, granting them unprecedented access to alternative sources of influence. **Peer interactions, social media platforms, and online communities have emerged as potent forces capable of shaping teenagers' perspectives, values and behaviours**. As these external influences gain prominence and as teenagers are exposed to a wider array of perspectives and sources of guidance beyond their familial realm, there is a possibility that the direct influence exerted by the family may become diluted.
3. The demands of the Singapore economy and the competitive school system has arguably **decreased the opportunities for families to interact**. Long work hours and school commitments have reduced the opportunities for parents to be aware of issues and provide guidance; driving teenagers to seek guidance from other sources such as the online community, their peers, or lifestyle 'influencers'.

2. To what extent is education an effective way to combat poverty?

Terms & Scope	
• ‘education’: Refers to both formal and informal education. However, the focus should be more on ‘formal education’ as it is the more contentious issue. By definition, ‘formal education’ refers to the <i>‘structured, systematic</i> learning process conducted within <i>established</i> educational institutions like schools, colleges, and universities’, typically involving a ‘defined curriculum, assessment methods, and leads to recognised credentials or certifications’. • ‘poverty’: a general lack of financial resources and basic necessities for a ‘decent’ standard of living; comprises both ‘absolute’ (lack of basic needs) and ‘relative’ (income and resources significantly lower than the average in society) poverty. • ‘effective way’: the approaches used that successfully achieves desired outcomes / goals in ‘combating poverty’. • ‘combat’: action taken to reduce, eliminate and/or prevent something bad or undesirable.	
Band 4 & above	Band 3
• Examines and evaluates how certain features of education address or entrench poverty. • Covers both types of poverty – relative and absolute • Considers the multi-faceted nature of poverty and examines to what extent can education address these issues.	• Shows the relationship between education and poverty but not as thorough in addressing how certain features of education or wider forces affects education’s effectiveness. • Lapses into arguments about how education causes income inequality and not addressing issue of poverty consistently Band 2 • Lists benefits/limitations of education without explaining how they may be seen as effective/ineffective in dealing with poverty • Focus is only on income inequality

Reasons why education is an effective way to combat poverty

1. **On a very basic level, the development of literacy and numerical skills at the elementary level provides the essential foundation to access future employment opportunities and enable social mobility, thereby keeping poverty at bay. By investing in accessible and high-quality education, countries can also strengthen their workforce and accelerate national development.** Singapore provides a strong example of how aligning education with economic development can lift a nation out of poverty. Today, as the economy shifts toward high-value industries such as AI, finance, and digital services, the government has updated its education policies to prioritise 21st century competencies—such as critical thinking, digital literacy, and innovation. This strategic alignment between education and evolving economic needs has helped keep poverty rates low and ensured that Singaporeans, regardless of background, can continue to thrive. Research at UNESCO has also shown that world poverty would be more than halved if all adults completed secondary school.

2. **Education that promotes holistic development and critical thinking empowers individuals not just to escape poverty themselves, but to challenge the structures that keep others trapped in it.** In addition to teaching knowledge and skills required for employment, a well-rounded education cultivates awareness of social justice, civic responsibility, and human rights. Educated women in many parts of the world have become vocal advocates for gender equality, fighting for women's rights to education and fair treatment in the workplace. A notable example is Malala Yousafzai, who used her education and influence to push back against oppressive norms in Pakistan that denied girls basic schooling. In India, organizations like Pratham and Teach for India not only deliver basic education to underserved communities but also train young leaders from those very communities to return and advocate for better public services, clean water, and housing. When education goes beyond exam preparation to include civic awareness and leadership development, it empowers individuals to become advocates for their communities, creating lasting, structural change that helps others escape the poverty cycle
3. **Furthermore, the meritocratic systems of most educational institutions in developed societies aim at levelling the playing field, granting those from disadvantaged backgrounds equal access to opportunities previously enjoyed only by the privileged in society.** China's dramatic economic rise in the past five decades has been attributed to its strong meritocratic system stemming from its Confucianism ideals. They pride themselves for the fairness of their Chinese civil service exam system from which leaders are chosen to govern the country. Scholarships in premier American universities are handed out based on merit rather than socio-economic backgrounds, offering the less privileged the chance to excel academically, and professionally, in their respective areas of expertise. Therefore, meritocracy's aspiration to 'iron out' socio-economic differences provide a critical springboard and impetus to prevent and break the poverty cycle in time to come.

Reasons why education's effectiveness in combating poverty is limited:

1. **When educational opportunities are unevenly distributed, particularly along lines of race, income, or geography, education can reinforce rather than reduce cycles of poverty.** In the United States, students in poorer, predominantly Black inner-city communities often attend underfunded public schools with limited access to qualified teachers, extracurricular programs, and updated facilities. These schools struggle to provide the same quality of education as those in wealthier suburban districts, which are well-funded by higher local property taxes. Similarly, in China, the hukou (household registration) system creates structural inequality by tying public services—including education—to a citizen's registered birthplace. Migrant workers who move from rural areas to cities often cannot enroll their children in urban public schools. These children are forced to attend poorly resourced rural schools or informal migrant schools with low teaching standards and basic infrastructure. Hence, unless government policies work to reduce inequalities, students from disadvantaged communities will face greater barriers to college admission and high-paying careers, perpetuating intergenerational poverty.
2. Education alone is not a guarantee of social mobility as its **relevance to economic needs may be a factor as well.** Arguably, pursuing a very niche degree or seemingly frivolous course might not provide the promised employment opportunities. It could impede one's chances to escape the poverty trap, or worse, be further entrenched in it due to the debt caused by expensive school fees. In many developing nations, outdated, overly academic, or

exam-focused curricula fail to provide students with the practical or technical skills needed for good employment opportunities. The Philippines, for instance, produces a high number of college graduates each year, but many are unable to find suitable jobs domestically due to skill mismatches. As a result, a large portion of the educated workforce is compelled to seek low-skilled employment overseas (often in domestic work or caregiving), where their formal education provides little economic mobility.

3. **Education may have limited effect due to larger systemic forces** that generate poverty in society. Widespread economic stagnation or poor economic conditions may create a situation where many remain unemployed or barely earn enough to make ends meet despite being educated. Poor economic conditions may create a situation where many remain unemployed or barely earn enough to make ends meet despite being educated. Despite holding college degrees, many workers in the U.S. now struggle to make ends meet as the cost of living rises while wages remain largely stagnant. Coupled with the fact that millions of students take on significant student loan debt, often without any guarantee of securing high-paying employment after graduation, education can ironically become a barrier rather than a pathway to escaping the poverty trap. Or consider the situation in China with high youth unemployment even though many are undergraduates. Many are forced to rely on parents for their income needs as they are unable to find steady employment as well as paying relatively expensive rent to live near the city for job opportunities.

3. 'There is no such thing as privacy today.' Comment.

Terms & Scope	
• 'No such thing': An absolute term. Suggests the total erosion of privacy — that privacy, as a concept or reality, is extinct. • 'Privacy': Refers to the right or ability of individuals or entities to control access to personal information, activities, spaces, or thoughts. Can span digital, physical, legal, and psychological dimensions. • 'Today': Focus on the contemporary era — especially the digital age marked by mass surveillance, data mining, AI-powered surveillance, social media, and global interconnectivity.	
Band 4 & above	Band 3
• Addresses absolute nature of the claim ("no such thing") • Shows understanding of "privacy" in various spheres — not just digital. • Looks into the effectiveness of measures to maintain privacy • Analyses trends, e.g. how the line between public and private has shifted due to social norms and tech developments.	• Fails to interpret "no such thing" as an absolute and treat the question as a generic 'pros and cons of tech and privacy' discussion. • Focuses too narrowly on social media (e.g. Facebook, Instagram) without addressing broader systemic issues like surveillance capitalism, algorithmic profiling, or the role of governments.

Reasons why our privacy has become incredibly limited today

1. **Surveillance is ubiquitous and unavoidable, erasing meaningful personal boundaries.** Governments and corporations constantly collect data through CCTV, drones, facial recognition, and smartphone tracking. These forms of surveillance often occur without explicit consent, making it nearly impossible for individuals to opt out, thereby rendering personal privacy obsolete.
2. **Digital platforms thrive on the commodification of personal data and this has become so normalised that our privacy is constantly at stake.** In the age of surveillance capitalism, tech companies profit by harvesting user data — from browsing habits to voice recordings — to fuel algorithms and targeted advertising. Many companies offer huge incentives to utilise their apps which track user data extensively. Since participation in the digital economy is nearly unavoidable, individuals are coerced into trading privacy for access.
3. **Social norms have shifted to normalise self-exposure, dissolving the boundary between public and private.** Social media culture encourages oversharing and constant online visibility. With the rise of apps like TikTok, BeReal, and Instagram Stories, people voluntarily broadcast intimate details of their lives, not realising the long-term implications on privacy, identity, and security. Furthermore, **Individuals have traded privacy for convenience, often without fully realising the extent of what they have given up.** From smart speakers like Alexa and Google Home that passively record daily interactions, to social media platforms where users voluntarily share intimate details of their lives. Despite growing awareness of these intrusions, privacy fatigue sets in — many users feel powerless and resigned. They click "accept all cookies," skip reading privacy policies, and continue using these services, believing that sacrificing privacy is the unavoidable cost of participation in digital life.

Reasons why privacy is still a thing today

- 1. Political and legal frameworks have established clear boundaries to protect privacy rights.**
Data protection laws like the EU's GDPR and Singapore's PDPA mandate how organisations handle personal data, with severe penalties for breaches. These legal safeguards reinforce the idea that privacy is a right that still exists and can be enforced.
- 2. Individuals have access to tools and choices that allow them to retain control over their information.** Encrypted messaging apps, VPNs, cookie blockers, and privacy settings on social media platforms empower users to limit what they reveal. These tools create meaningful layers of protection and show that privacy is possible when individuals take conscious action.
- 3. Cultural and political resistance to surveillance is growing, leading to greater scrutiny and accountability.** The shocking revelations by whistleblowers like Edward Snowden and digital rights groups have exposed the extent of surveillance and fought to curb its excesses. Since then, this increasing awareness has prompted shifts in public behaviour and policy reforms, indicating that privacy can still be defended in today's world. Today, we see Whistleblowers like Sarah Wynn-Williams, former global public policy director at Facebook, who told US Senators that Meta ignored national security concerns to build its \$18 billion business in China. She said executives at the company decided to provide CCP the access to data of its users. She also said that the one thing the Chinese Communist Party & Mark Zuckerberg share is that they both want to silence their critics.

4. Do you agree that the use of technology for education is not always beneficial?

Terms & Scope	
• 'Use of technology for education': Refers to tools deliberately designed or intentional utilisation of technological tools to improve formal educational outcomes. May consider not just the types or forms of technology used, but the ways technology is used to enhance education, or the different aspects of education technology that is being used for, including instruction and learning, assessment, facilitating collaboration. • 'always': at all times, it suggests that the use of technology is <i>beneficial in every context and for every learner</i>. • 'beneficial': Could be understood to mean helpful or constructive insofar as enhancing education or attaining educational objectives. Could also mean benign, or not likely to cause any harm, even in ways that might be unrelated to the effectiveness of education	
Band 4 & above	Band 3
• Addresses impact of technology on education and educational outcomes. • Explains how technology interacts with the aims and outcomes of education • Engages with 'always' • Cognisance of relationships across space (different societal/developmental contexts e.g. developed vs developing societies) e.g. the beneficence of technological tools in education may depend on the profile/characteristics of the class/students and time (differences between past, present and future)	• Largely lists harms and benefits of technology for education and there is some attempt (implicit or otherwise) to link harm/benefits to the effectiveness of education or the wellbeing of stakeholders in education Low Band 3: • Discussion focuses on the use of technology for personal learning instead of for formal education Band 2: • General discussion of technology with no reference to technology for Education

Why the use of technology for education is generally/mostly beneficial:

1. On a fundamental level, **the potential for technology to democratise access to education** is of great significance, such that education can continue to function as the great leveller. Whether in the context of reconnecting groups that are physically isolated or socially marginalised to the education system or learning communities, the use of technology to overcome such barriers and allows for easier access to resources to ensure that the benefits of education can be shared more equitably.
2. The use of technology in education has **tremendous potential in making the learning experience much more engaging**, either through the provision of more novel settings, or in terms of allowing teachers to cater to different learning preferences and styles. Simultaneously, with greater engagement comes improved concentration and an active rather than passive attachment with the content/subject matter, which would serve to enhance motivation. Research has shown that the use of game-based learning platforms such as Kahoot can increase attention, enhance motivation for working in groups, and sustain engagement over time

3. **The calibrated use of technology has also been a gamechanger in terms of making independent learning much more viable, convenient, and measurable.** Not only is this helpful in terms of allowing teachers/schools/formal education to focus on higher order/more complex learning activities in the classroom, it is also immensely useful in providing students opportunities to inculcate/develop useful learning dispositions, as well as aid in fostering self-directed learning and student empowerment. In fact, the latter are long-term benefits that are arguably more compelling, given how self-direction and a positive attitude towards learning constitute one of the most important aims of education. For example, Purposefully-designed learning activities via Google Classroom and Student Learning Space (SLS) offers helpful scaffolds and allow students to work independently and creatively.

Why the use of technology for education is not beneficial at times:

1. **It is an oft-used adage, but it is true nonetheless that technology is merely a tool, not a panacea.** How beneficial a tool is to any endeavour depends greatly on how appropriately and skilfully it has been wielded. If technological tools are judiciously used, and complement sound, effective learning pedagogies, they can significantly enhance learning outcomes. However, it is quite probable that given how much hype and hyperbole there is surrounding educational technologies and technology-infused educational models like blended learning, that the utilisation of technological tools become shallow and symbolic, which means that it would end up subverting the original purpose of supporting and enhancing student learning.
2. Given how immersive and captivating technology can potentially be, its utilisation for the purpose of enhancing learning outcomes does involve teachers and schools **making a trade-off between improved engagement and the greater risk of students becoming distracted, or missing out on the actual learning outcomes.** Should the balance not be properly struck, or the introduction of technological tools not carefully and appropriately conceived and executed, this strategy may end up becoming counterproductive, worsening rather than enhancing student learning.
3. **Improper use of technology might lead to overreliance and undermines the learning process in the long run.** The convenience of today's tech tools from learning apps, the internet in general, AI has made it too easy for students to use them unethically and unwisely for their education needs. An ST report highlighted how 80% of secondary students surveyed used AI at least once a week to do their homework. . This overdependence has, as some students admit, "taken away a lot of the motivation for learning," as they increasingly allow AI to do the thinking for them. For the sake of efficiency, student sacrifice the thorough understanding that comes from personal effort, mistakes, and seeing connections through application.
4. **The use of technology in education is not always beneficial, particularly when unequal access to digital infrastructure exacerbates existing educational disparities.** In India, when schools closed during the Covid-19 lockdown in March 2020, over 247 million children had to rely on remote learning. In states like Karnataka, where only a quarter of households had Internet access, students in rural areas struggled with unstable connectivity, preventing them from participating meaningfully in online learning or maintaining a structured learning routine. Similarly, in Singapore, despite government efforts to bridge the digital divide during the pandemic in 2020—

such as the loan of over 12,500 laptops and 1,200 dongles according to the Ministry of Education —some low-income families without household Wi-Fi continued to face challenges.

5.To what extent does your society truly care for its underprivileged people?

Terms & Scope	
• ‘Underprivileged’: individuals or groups who lack access to resources, opportunities, and usually require external support (e.g NGOs, state support) for daily needs. • ‘Truly care’: Social attitudes/Care/Policies/Initiatives that are <i>thoughtful, well-researched, sustained, effective</i> – demonstrative of a <i>genuine</i> desire to help/uplift/alleviate the problems of the underprivileged. • ‘Your society’: Demonstrate a sensitivity to/awareness of the context of modern Singapore (e.g. cultural values, focus on strong economic performance, multiculturalism, technological advancements) that could affect Singapore in caring for the underprivileged.	
Band 4 & above	Band 3 & below
• Response addresses what ‘truly care’ entails and whether current efforts are reflective of this such as its effectiveness, sincerity, congruence, conviction, etc. • Considers a range of ‘underprivileged people’ in Singapore society and how care given might be uneven across these segments • Considers a range of relevant actors (the state, community groups, citizens) and their care for the underprivileged	• Merely lists initiatives/actions taken to help underprivileged people in Singapore instead of evaluating if this means ‘true care’ (e.g. doesn’t show impact of these initiatives) Low Band 3 • Merely lists the types of underprivileged people and their issues Band 2 • Focuses on groups that may experience some form of inequality but would not be classified as underprivileged by most organisations. E.g LGBTQ, the elderly in general

Why Singapore does not truly care for its underprivileged people

1. Because many of **Singapore’s policies are aimed at encouraging specific societal norms**, underprivileged people who do not fit these prevailing norms often find that their needs are ignored by larger society or the government. Many single parents in Singapore, who are often single due to reasons not within their control, are from low-income households. Yet due to the government’s aim of creating policies that encourage parenthood within marriage, they still find themselves excluded from benefits such as the Baby Bonus cash entitlement, and those in the workforce are also not eligible for parenthood tax rebates and the Working Mothers Child Relief.
2. Due to the **national narrative of meritocracy** that has become ingrained in our culture, **many Singaporeans may hold the belief that one’s impoverishment is because one’s poor choices, lack of ability, or lack of effort**. This, coupled with a lack of understanding about the lived experiences of the poor, results in the lack of genuine compassion for people who are disadvantaged, and the failure to effectively assist them. Consequently, a common criticism made is that many efforts to help the underprivileged

in Singapore are often tokenistic and short-lived, and cannot be said to reflect true commitment to resolving the issues facing them. For example, many local students complete Values-In-Action projects often only to meet VIA requirements, and do not sustain their interactions with their beneficiary groups after these requirements are met. This empty volunteerism extends also to companies that engage in one-time corporate social responsibility efforts simply to meet CSR targets. Some efforts to help might also be well-intentioned, but not carefully considered, and thus insensitive to the needs of vulnerable individuals. In 2021, Singaporeans were urged by MSF Minister Sun Xueling as well as social services organisations not to post images and details of the homeless people that they came across, as this would be more detrimental to them than helpful.

Why Singapore truly cares for its underprivileged people

1. Despite its insistence on self-reliance, the **government recognises how social and economic shifts have impacted Singaporeans' ability to fend for themselves and support their families** and thus **have expanded their support** for low-income families and individuals. A rapidly ageing population, dwindling fertility rate and sandwiched generation has meant that family resources and assistance as the primary means of social support is shrinking over time, and coupled with Singapore's susceptibility to globalisation trends and the displacement of older, less qualified workers in Singapore's knowledge-based economy, that not everyone is able to get by without support. Thus, the government has a wide array of policies aimed at addressing the needs of different underprivileged groups in Singapore, and these policies are constantly reviewed so as to make them more effective in meeting the needs of their target beneficiaries. The expansion of these social support programmes also reflects the growing maturity of Singaporeans, who have become more receptive to the notions of social justice and collective responsibility. For example, there are financial subsidies for lower-income households to make quality healthcare accessible and affordable, and the government has regularly made MediSave top-ups for more vulnerable groups such as the Pioneer Generation. Furthermore, the Ministry of Social and Family Development (MSF)'s Social Service Offices and community partners proactively reach out to vulnerable groups, such as lower-income families, to ensure that their daily needs are met. In recent years, there has also been a shift in focus towards more upstream interventions for low-income families that focuses on helping their children, so that, through education and employment, the next generation can break out of the poverty cycle.
2. **Due to greater awareness and advocacy by NGOs and community groups**, there has been more public education about the issues faced by the underprivileged in Singapore, and consequently **a significant increase in the number of thoughtful initiatives implemented to truly address the needs of the underprivileged in society**. For example, NGOs like Humanitarian Organization for Migration Economics (HOME) and Transient Workers Count Too (TWC2) have been working very closely with migrant workers in Singapore for years. Having a clear understanding of the specific struggles they face, such as abuse and exploitation, they have been working to empower and support them through a range of methods: direct crisis intervention, training programmes, outreach projects and public education. There have been coordinated efforts between the government, social service agencies and community volunteers to try to provide holistic support for low-income households through applying for financial assistance, finding employment or upskilling opportunities, and providing socio-emotional support. In recent years, the government had recognised the difficulties in which the underprivileged faced

and have made changes in an attempt to address those issues. For example, the 2023 Budget speech now allows for single mothers (specifically) to claim Working Mothers Child Relief

3. **Singapore's government has ensured that quality education remains accessible for all** by providing various financial assistance schemes to prevent the underprivileged from falling through the cracks, even to the extent of providing free education for them. In recent years, free preschool education has been made available for students from low-income families, helping to bridge the social divide by establishing a strong foundation at a young age.

6. Is competition always desirable?

Terms & Scope • ‘always desirable’: Is it necessarily the case that competition is good/advantageous (“desirable”) in every context (“always”)? • ‘Competition’: any form of rivalry or where the notion of winning/losing is relevant, with the winner establishing superiority/advantage(s) over the loser	
Band 4 & above • Shows an awareness of the absolute term. • Provides a measured stance that will reconcile the good with the negative outcomes of competitions. • Responses will show some clarity on the stakeholders who will find competitions (un)desirable and uses wider variety of competition	Band 3 • Responses will merely list advantages/disadvantages of competition Low Band 3 • Limited scope of discussion such as only talking about it from a sporting perspective or impact from only an individual’s perspective.

When competition would be deemed desirable

Broadly, competition is desirable when it is the **healthy kind that encourages us to work harder, strive to be better/our best, and push past barriers that may be limiting or restricting us**. In such scenarios, “winning” is not about ‘defeating’ others but about improving ourselves by gauging our level of performance against that of others so that we make positive steps forward in our accomplishments without the notion that others must be ‘beaten’ or disadvantaged.

1. In areas of personal development and achievement such as studies or work, competition can provide **extrinsic motivation to do better which supplements intrinsic motivation**, leading to positive, desired outcomes for the individual. In the education context, in addition to learning more about what interests and excites us, vying with others for entry into desired courses or schools can **drive us to work harder, put in (more) effort, even surmount challenges** – the overall outcome being attaining not just the desired subject mastery but also lifelong soft skills such as goal-setting, perseverance, and resilience. At work, vying for higher ranking that can lead to promotion and better pay can similarly drive individuals to good or better performance that could also lift the efforts of one’s team/department/company.
2. **Healthy competition provides wider positive values and outcomes for the community.** Competitive achievements be it in sports, the arts, can be a source of national pride. E.g Olympics, the Oscars. For spectators, competition raises the level of excitement and engagement, where the victories of one’s team or compatriot(s) often lift the mood and can serve as a unifying force.
3. Competition is vital in economic terms. It drives innovation in businesses that can lead to not just **better products and services** but also **more choice** for consumers. And when people spend money on such goods and services, it helps to create income and more jobs. This is also seen on the global level, where countries that strive for and sustain comparative advantage in specific markets can produce cheaper, faster, and better, benefitting

consumers and boosting their trading capacity with global markets, the latter being particularly vital for less-developed or developing economies.

When competition would be deemed undesirable

Broadly, competition is undesirable when it is (or is perceived to be) the kind that involves “winning” **at all costs**. This often involves a skewed sense of ‘achievement’ or ‘superiority’ that leads to **unhealthy or obsessive** behaviours and attitudes about the need to always ‘defeat’ others or ‘be the best’.

1. An obsessive fixation with “winning” – when we perceive ‘accomplishment’ as being “superior” to others – can **blind us to the improvements** that we are making. Instead, we may set up **unrealistic targets** of achievement and, worse, beat ourselves up when we believe that we have ‘failed to win’. In Singapore, some students’ (and parents’) skewed sense of what “winning” in academic “competition” looks like (scoring ‘perfect’ As) has not just birthed an arguably unhealthy tuition culture but also led to increasing levels of stress. Ironically, such a superficial grades-based view of “winning” may hinder students from developing more lasting and important mindsets and skills that could ultimately be far more effective in terms of “winning” in academic terms (e.g. self-confidence, genuine curiosity, accepting ‘failure’ as a key step in attaining success).
2. **Competitions may undermine values, cooperation and damages interpersonal relationships.** In the workplace, for instance, intense internal competition—such as when companies implement aggressive performance ranking systems—can create a toxic environment where employees are more focused on outperforming each other than on sharing knowledge or collaborating effectively. This undermines team cohesion and leads to a loss of trust, which can hurt overall productivity in the long run. In sport, the desire to win at all costs can make a mockery so many of its core positive values and lead to undesirable outcomes. Cheating (e.g. taking ‘performance-enhancing’ substances) and unsportsmanlike behaviour (e.g. intentionally injuring a competitor) undermine the essence of “fair play” in healthy competition, and in turn may instil skewed notions of “winning” in the minds of those (especially the young) who look up to sports personalities.
3. Businesses that narrowly focus on ‘beating the competition’ may resort to **unethical practices** that hurt their employees and/or shortchange their consumers. If “winning” is seen mainly in terms of minimising cost to emerge more “profitable” than rivals, companies may exploit or abuse their workers (e.g. unfair wages, poor working conditions). When being ‘superior’ involves pushing out new products as quickly as possible, **quality control and/or meaningful innovation may be sidelined**, resulting in goods and services that fail to deliver what they promise, contributing to a “throwaway” culture that ultimately also harms the environment.

7. ‘The purpose of the justice system should be rehabilitation, not punishment.’ Discuss.

Question requirements: • ‘justice system’ → Network of government and private agencies intended to (= “purpose”) manage accused and convicted criminals <i>fairly and effectively</i> in order to reduce and/or prevent criminal or unlawful activity. • ‘should be’ → Implicit meaning of expectations or there being positive outcomes of one approach over the other. • ‘punishment’ → Pain or penalty warranted by law, inflicted on a person for <i>committing</i> a crime or misdemeanour contrary to the law, or for the <i>omission</i> of the performance of an act required by law. • ‘rehabilitation’ → Process of helping inmates grow and change, with the aim of helping inmates live a crime-free life after their release from incarceration.	
Band 4 and above	Band 3
• Consistently provides clear <i>reasons</i> why the purpose of the justice system should or should not be rehabilitation rather than punishment • Discusses the problems and benefits of the two schools of thought. • Considerations to justify why rehab should or should not be the sole purpose compared to punishment. • Examines how one method over the other affects the inmate or its suitability to the crime that was committed.	• Listing mainly advantages and limitations of rehabilitation and punishment but not evaluating why one should be favoured over another. • Response answers address ‘should’ as ‘can’ – e.g. discussing what rehabilitation and punishment are able to achieve (i.e. listing of cause-effect). No comparison between the two approaches.

Why/When rehabilitation better serves the puporse of the justice system

1. **Rehabilitation is seen as more humane than severe forms of punishment** (e.g. corporal and capital), and it reflects a justice system that reflects and upholds societal ideals such as mercy, compassion, and valuing the sanctity of life.
2. **Rehabilitation reflects a shaper calibration of justice for crimes committed by the young who have a reduced culpability for their crimes due to lack of capacity or by those in desperate situations.** This emphasises the key aims of a fair and civilised justice system that tries to ensure that “the punishment fits the crime” (vs purely retributive punishment). Rehabilitation that is tailored to suit the offender’s profile, background and challenges may also tackle the root causes of criminal’s actions more effectively than the broader tool of punishment. This includes considering the systemic inequalities that may have led to criminal activities.

3. **Rehabilitation can be said to be more effective both in reducing recidivism** (chances of inmates reoffending) and in helping criminals to reform and reintegrate into society – a win-win for all members of society that makes for effective management of crime and offenders. Harsh punishment has not always translated to lower crime rates, and often disproportionately affects marginalised groups. Norway, for instance, has some of the world's lowest recidivism rates precisely because its prisons focus on therapy, education, and humane treatment. In contrast, others argue that the justice system must serve as a tool of retribution - punishing those who violate laws to uphold moral order and provide closure to victims. The United States' more punitive model, with mandatory minimum sentences and the death penalty in some states, reflects this belief.

The ideal justice system must balance both aims, recognising that while punishment satisfies societal demands for justice, rehabilitation creates the conditions for lasting safety and moral repair. A system focused solely on one risk either appearing too lenient or becoming inhumane.

Why/when rehabilitation may not be as suitable/effective as punishment in achieving the aims of a justice system

1. **Punishment (incarceration; corporal; capital) may be more suitable in cases involving high-harm crimes and/or unrepentant offenders, better meeting the aims of retribution and incapacitation.** In such cases, rehabilitation can seem too light and indulgent, causing even more pain for the victims and their loved ones. It creates the optics that justice has not been served and potentially undermines trust in the system over time.
2. **Punishment may also send a stronger deterrence signal** to would-be criminals, either by taking recalcitrant offenders out of circulation in society or instilling a sense of fear in potential offenders about the harsh consequences that may follow their crimes. For example, the strict anti-drug laws in Singapore have put a tighter lid on this scourge than in other countries with less punitive measures, emphasising that rehabilitation may not be as effective in nipping serious crimes or pressing problems in the bud. (refer to USA example mentioned previously in point 3 *for rehabilitation*)
3. **Poorly conceived rehabilitation programmes that lean too heavily on leniency may increase criminality when offenders are returned to society or even when they are still in prison.** Indeed, a former UK director general of Prison Service has declared that "[t]he things we did to prisoners, the courses we put them on, the involvement of charities, made little or no difference", especially if the conditions in correctional facilities are poor or poorly managed. *[NOTE: This is not an argument for punishment per se, but rather one that challenges simplistic rose-tinted views of rehabilitation programmes.]*

8. 'It is increasing difficult to be a man today.' Discuss.

Question requirements: 'Key Terms' 1. "increasingly" → growing in type/number/degree 2. "to be a man" → socio-cultural expectations in behavioural traits, roles, responsibilities; popular opinion/ media depictions of masculinity; traditional/conventional claims to rights, power and privilege 3. "today" → Showing awareness of modern day forces that shifts perspectives on gender identity.	
Band 4 and above • Addresses the difficulty in meeting societal norms and expectations • Addresses the term 'increasingly' > how things are getting more/difficult/easier • Examines impact of change across different societies • Examines reasons from various angles such as media, culture, legal alterations and so on	Band 3 • Able to show the problems faced by men • Listing advantages and problems of being a man today with vague explanation of what 'being a man' implies Band 2 • Focus is only on women - It is difficult to be a woman today • misinterpretation of 'man' as 'mankind', and discussed whether it is more difficult to be a human being today • Focusing more on the plight of women and comparatively how it is easier to be man in today's world.

It is more difficult to be a man today

1. **Changing gender norms in various spheres (family, workforce, politics, human rights) have elevated women's status in these arenas and consequently, destabilised male privilege** The role of men has historically been defined in opposition to women (eg. Men as the breadwinner and women as the caretaker), and hence these changing gender norms have required men to adapt. Unfortunately, there are no clear notions of how to best adjust to this change (eg. How does a man relate to the 'modern woman'; be an involved father). Men may also not receive adequate structural support as systems are still largely patriarchal such as the limited paternal leave in non-Nordic countries where one still assumes that men are the primary breadwinner. At worse, this insecurity also makes men vulnerable to dangerous, misogynistic ideals such as those touted by Andrew Tate and such advice would hold him back from adapting to the modern the world
2. **A more vague identity and expectation as conventional and privileged notions of heterosexual masculinity have been challenged** or complicated with the rise of alternative sexualities and masculinities (e.g. LGBTs, metrosexuality). This may lead to a re-examination of

what it means to be 'manly' or conversely to be challenged or even ridiculed if a man embraces such less traditional versions of masculinity.

3. Some systems discriminate men over time (particularly those that continue to push certain narratives and expectations on men. Compulsory military conscription tends to only be relevant for men as he is still expected to be the main protector while such occupations often do not welcome women or are hostile to her participation. Legal systems may also ignore men's concerns or penalise him. This includes trends such as male victims of domestic violence who face stigma and underreport because their claims are taken less seriously. And while false allegations of sexual assault are very rare, they can have devastating impacts on men as he may often be deemed already guilty before the public before due process in court.

It is not increasingly difficult to be a man today

1. Despite progress in gender equality, men still often benefit from structural and societal privileges. Systems today are still largely patriarchal and are designed for men in mind. This includes phenomenon such as the Old Boys Club where men still dominate top positions in politics, business, and religious institutions and therefore can make decisions that suit his needs. For example, over 90% of Fortune 500 CEOs are men. In terms of salary, in many places men continue to earn more on average than women. Laws in certain societies continue to favour men over women and the status quo has not changed much whether it is autonomy over their own body or freedom of movement. Men can also reinforce these systems to their advantage such as enacting the Wall Street Rule after the #MeToo movement where men in power refused to hire or mentor women.

2. Changing gender expectations may actually make it easier to be a man today. Men today are more socially empowered to express vulnerability and pursue non-traditional roles. For example, the stigma around men's mental health is being challenged, making it easier to seek help. In addition, men are increasingly accepted as caregivers or stay-at-home fathers, with less stigma than in previous generations. They're also freer and more respected to embark on careers which a generation ago would be seen as a woman's domain, such as nursing and early childhood educators.